WHO ARE THE MIYAS IN ASSAM?

Unlike in the rest of India, where 'Mian' still retains its old sense as a form of address to a respectable person, the term 'Miya' in Assam is a pejorative denoting Bangla-speaking Muslims of immigrant origin, whose numbers are estimated to be around 10 million currently. They are often perceived to have illegally entered India from Bangladesh. Though most of them claim to have stayed in Assam for generations, Assamese nationalist organisations have long been demanding their detection and deportation to Bangladesh. The draft National Register of Citizenship (NRC), prepared in 2019 under the supervision of the Supreme Court, to detect illegal immigrants in the state, found 1.9 million people who were not eligible for citizenship. While this number has been disputed by all stakeholders, the Miya community has responded to the crisis in variable ways: many seek acceptance within the Assamese spectrum, while some have chosen a more defiant vein, embracing the term 'Miya' to assert a distinctive identity. Thus, the demand for a Miya Museum and a celebration of Miya poetry. The latter, rendered in a variety of Bangla, runs up against a historical antagonism though, adding to the cocktail of ethnolinguistic and religious politics.

the BJP, the ruling party at the Centre and in the state, had made the NRC an electoral plank to woo Asomiya voters, the 2019 update has not been accepted so far. Initially, the pandemic was cited as the reason for the delay but critics say the reluctance to accept the NRC stems from the fact that nearly 50 per cent of those excluded are non-Muslims. To circumvent that, the BJP, many argue, is also keen to implement the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), 2019, in Assam as it would enable the granting of citizenship to illegal Hindu immigrants. A new Hindu-Muslim narrative was floated, especially by CM Sarma, saying the Hindu immigrants would strengthen the Assamese Hindus, who would otherwise be outnumbered by the Muslims of immigrant origin. Sarma, however, was careful to not offend Assamese-speaking Muslims. Among Assam's more than 10 million Muslims, around four million belong to five Assamese-speaking Muslim groups that have recently been declared as 'indigenous' by the BJP government to distinguish them from the Miyas.

WHY A MUSEUM FOR MIYAS

Many Muslims of immigrant origin have embraced the pejorative term thrust upon them—Miya—and use it to assert their distinctive identity. The Miya Museum was a reflection of that. "The museum came up because the larger Assamese society doesn't accept us as an integral part. I'm a Miya and I speak the Assamese language, yet I'm not acknowledged as Assamese," says Sherman Ali Ahmed, a suspended Congress legislator. Ahmed, who admits it was wrong to turn a private residence built under PMAY into a museum, had scored the second highest marks in the state in Assamese language in his Class 10 boards. In 2020, he had written to the state's director of museums, requesting him to expedite the construction of a Miya museum on the premises of the Srimanta Sankardev Kalakshetra in Guwahati, a cultural complex aimed at "preserving and promoting the cultural heritage of the people of Assam". In his letter, Ahmed cited a recommendation made by the Standing Committee on Art and Culture to the Assam assembly on March 24, 2020, that such a museum be set up in Kalakshetra to reflect "the culture and heritage of people living in the *char-chaporis*". "All communities and tribal groups in Assam are represented in Kalakshetra. Why can't the culture of Miyas find a place there? We don't want to be separated from Assamese culture, but be a part of it," says Ahmed.

But, for Assamese nationalists, this means legitimising 'illegal immigrants'. "There is no need to redefine the concept of Assam's indigenous population. The larger Assamese society is inclusive of everyone, including indigenous Muslims. Where is the need to create another identity?" asks Samujjal Kumar Bhattacharya, patron of the All Assam Students' Union (AASU), the organisation at the forefront of agitating against illegal immigrants. He dismisses the sundry "blame games" as "the insecurity of a particular group".



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SHERMAN ALI AHMED
Suspended Congress MLA

The idea is also not acceptable to someone like Apurba Adhikary, who heads a forum to protect the Satras, or Assam's Vaishnavite monasteries, from land-grabbing by immigrants. Adhikary, whose